

1. Hacking

In simple words, hacking is an act committed by an intruder by accessing your computer system without your permission. Hackers (the people doing the ‘hacking’) are basically computer programmers, who have an advanced understanding of computers and commonly misuse this knowledge for devious reasons. They’re usually technology buffs who have expert-level skills in one particular software program or language.

As for motives, there could be several, but the most common are pretty simple and can be explained by a human tendency such as greed, fame, power, etc. Some people do it purely to show-off their expertise – ranging from relatively harmless activities such as modifying software (and even hardware) to carry out tasks that are outside the creator’s intent, others just want to cause destruction.

Greed and sometimes voyeuristic tendencies may cause a hacker to break into systems to steal personal banking information, a corporation’s financial data, etc. They also try and modify systems so that they can execute tasks at their whims. Hackers displaying such destructive conduct are also called “Crackers” at times. They are also called “Black Hat” hackers.

On the other hand, there are those who develop an interest in computer hacking just out of intellectual curiosity. Some companies hire these computer enthusiasts to find flaws in their security systems and help fix them. Referred to as “White Hat” hackers, these guys are against the abuse of computer systems. They attempt to break into network systems purely to alert the owners of flaws. It’s not always altruistic, though, because many do this for fame as well, in order to land jobs with top companies, or just to be termed as security experts. “Grey Hat” is another term used to refer to hacking activities that are a cross between black and white hacking.

Some of the most famous computer geniuses were once hackers who went on to use their skills for constructive technological development. Dennis Ritchie and Ken Thompson, the creators of the UNIX operating system (Linux’s predecessor), were two of them. Shawn Fanning, the developer of Napster, Mark Zuckerberg of Facebook fame, and many more are also examples.

The first step towards preventing hackers from gaining access to your systems is to learn how hacking is done. Of course it is beyond the scope of this Fast Track to go into great details, but we will cover the various techniques used by hackers to get to you via the internet.

- a. **SQL Injections:** An SQL injection is a technique that allows hackers to play upon the security vulnerabilities of the software that runs a web site.